PHILOSOPHICAL PERSPECTIVES OF THE SELF

MODULE 1: ANCIENT PHILOSOPHERS

1. Socrates

- **Core Definition:** "Philosophy" means the love of wisdom. Understanding the self allows us to know who we are and become better.
- **Method of Study:** The self is best understood through **introspection and questioning**.
- **The Soul:** Considered the true self, distinct from the body, immortal, and the source of moral and intellectual virtues. Focuses on the full power of reason in the human self.
- **Core Questions:**
    - Who are we?
    - Whom should we be?
    - Whom will we become?
- **Key Principles:**
    - Virtue comes from knowledge.
    - **Socratic Method:** Questioning as a path to self-knowledge.
- **Famous Maxim:** *"An unexamined life is not worth living."*

2. Plato

- **Famous Maxim:** *"Know Thyself"*.
- **Dualism of Man:** A human being is made up of:
    - **Body:** Physical, temporary, belonging to the material world.
    - **Soul:** Eternal, rational, true self, belonging to the Realm of Forms.
- **Realm of Forms:** A hidden, eternal world of perfect ideas, including concepts like beauty, justice, and goodness. When the soul entered the body, it forgot much of this knowledge.
- **Theory of Recollection:** Learning is simply remembering what the soul already knew.
- **Three Parts of the Soul:**
    - **Reason:** Thinks logically and seeks the truth. *Example:* Studying instead of procrastinating because you know it's beneficial.
    - **Spirit:** Produces courage, ambition, and determination. *Example:* Standing up for a classmate who is being bullied.
    - **Appetite:** Desires pleasure and physical satisfaction. *Example:* Wanting junk food, excessive gaming, or unnecessary spending.
- **The Healthy Self & Well-being (Diagram Breakdown):**
    - **Reason** finds/guides.
    - **Spirit** supports reason.
    - **Appetite** is kept under control.
    - **Harmony leads to well-being**. If human beings do not live in accordance with their nature or function, the result is injustice.
- **Education Helps the Soul:** People who see only shadows mistake appearances for reality. Education helps them "leave the cave" and understand deeper truths (moving beyond what you see on the surface).

3. Aristotle

- **Core Definition:** The self is a combination (unity) of body and soul.
    - **Body:** Physical aspect of the person.
    - **Soul:** Gives meaning and purpose (*telos*).
- **Types of Souls Table:**
    - **Nutritive Soul:** Found in **Plants** | Function: Growth, nutrition, reproduction.
    - **Sensitive Soul:** Found in **Animals** | Function: Sensation, movement, desire.
    - **Rational Soul:** Found in **Humans** | Function: Reasoning, reflection, moral decision-making.
- **Human Flourishing (*Eudaimonia*):**
    - Humans flourish by fulfilling their highest function.
    - *Eudaimonia* is the goal of life (*Eu* = good, *daimon* = spirit or god).
    - **Reason** makes us truly human. Understanding yourself means developing that capacity to reason.
    - Knowing what is right is not enough; **virtue** must be developed through habit.
- **The Golden Mean:** Virtue is balanced between two extremes.
    - **Cowardice** ↔ **Courage** (Virtue) ↔ **Recklessness**
    - **Stinginess** ↔ **Generosity** (Virtue) ↔ **Wastefulness**
    - **Shyness** ↔ **Confidence** (Virtue) ↔ **Arrogance**
    - **Laziness** ↔ **Diligence** (Virtue) ↔ **Workaholism**
    - **Self-indulgence** ↔ **Temperance** (Virtue) ↔ **Overindulgence**

MODULE 2: MEDIEVAL TO MODERN PHILOSOPHERS

4. St. Augustine

- **Background:** African philosopher, regarded as a saint in the Catholic Church. *(Note/Fan ni Plato)*
- **Understanding the Self:**
    - Involves looking inward and recognizing our relationship with God.
    - Human beings are created by God and possess a spiritual nature. Everything created by God, who is all good, is good.
    - **Inner self (soul) > External appearances (body)**
    - We are free, but our choices matter.
- **Methods & Desires:**
    - Self-reflection helps discover desires, weaknesses, and our need for God through **prayer and confession**.
    - Human beings naturally search for happiness and fulfillment through success, money, relationships, pleasure, and achievements, but these only provide temporary satisfaction.
- **Famous Maxim:** *"Our hearts are restless until they rest in you."* (Confessions)

Application Scenario (Exam Dilemma): *Scenario:* Tomorrow you have a major exam, but your friends invite you to an overnight outing.

- **Socrates:** Have you honestly examined why you're making this decision?
- **Plato:** Which part of the soul is making the decision—reason, spirit, or appetite?
- **Aristotle:** What would be the balanced, virtuous choice that will help you flourish?

- **St. Augustine:** Does this choice align with your spiritual nature and inner self rather than temporary pleasures?

5. René Descartes

- **Background:** French philosopher, known as the **father of modern philosophy**.
- **Method of Doubt:** Questioned everything he could doubt until he found one thing he cannot doubt—**thinking** as proof of one's existence.
- **Dualism:**
  - **Self (Soul):** A thinking mind (*res cogitans*); does the thinking, doubting, and believing.
  - **Body:** Physical (*res extensa*); occupies space.
  - *Note:* The soul and body are independent and can exist and function without each other.
- **Famous Maxim: *Cogito, ergo sum* ("I think, therefore I am")**.
- **Thought Experiment on Reality:**
  - *The Dream Argument:* You are dreaming you are in your classroom seeing classmates and feeling chairs, then you wake up realizing it wasn't real. How do you know you aren't dreaming right now?
  - *(Self-Note/Joke)*: "Cognitive miser - ayaw mo lang mag isip".

6. John Locke

- **Background:** English philosopher.
- **The Mind at Birth:** The human mind is a **blank slate (*tabula rasa*)**. The self is constructed primarily from sense experiences.
- **Personal Identity & Continuity:**
  - Personal identity is directly connected to **consciousness**.
  - **Memory** connects our past self to our present self.
  - **Keys to understanding the self:** Consciousness and memory.

7. David Hume

- **Background:** Scottish philosopher.
- **The Illusion of a Permanent Self:** Questioned the idea that there is a single, unchanging self.
- **Bundle Theory:** The self is a **bundle of perceptions** (a collection of changing thoughts, experiences, and feelings we have over time).
- **Fleeting Perceptions:** Random moments and snapshots from our lives. Self-identity is strictly a **mental construct**.

8. Immanuel Kant

- **Unifying Consciousness:** The self is a unified consciousness that makes it possible for us to experience all different things as belonging to one "I" (an active subject, not just a sum of your experiences).
- **Transcendental Unity of Apperception:** Our minds bring everything together.
- **Two Sides of the Self:**
  - **Empirical Self:** The self we show the world.
  - **Noumenal Self:** The deeper, unknowable self beyond our senses.

9. Sigmund Freud

- **Levels of the Mind:**

    - **Conscious:** Thoughts we are currently aware of.
    - **Preconscious:** Memories and stored knowledge.
    - **Unconscious:** Deep, hidden feelings and desires. Much of who we are lies here.
- **Three Structures of Personality:**
    - **Id:** Operates on instinctual desires and urges.
    - **Ego:** The rational part that balances desires with reality.
    - **Superego:** The moral conscience.
- **Freudian Slip:** An unconscious feeling leaking out. *Example:* Calling someone you dislike by the name of your ex, then apologizing ("Sorry, I don't know why I said that").

Ethical Responsibility Question:

- If there is no permanent self (Hume), what makes you responsible for your past actions? (e.g., A student cheated 10 years ago and is now a completely different person).
- *Resolution notes:* Still connected through the **memory of the past**. That past connects us to where we are right now. Change happens because of past occurrences, making us accountable for the continuity.

MODULE 3: CONTEMPORARY PHILOSOPHERS

10. Gilbert Ryle

- **Critique of Dualism:** Argued that the mind is not a separate identity or "ghost in the machine." Believed the self is not some inner ghost controlling the body as a separate invisible substance.
- **Behaviorism:** The self **manifests in behavior and actions** (a pattern of behavior). To understand the self, observe what a person does.

11. Paul Churchland

- **Background:** Canadian philosopher.
- **Eliminative Materialism:** The radical claim that our common-sense understanding of the mind called **"folk psychology"** is a false theory.
- **The Self is the Brain:** Mental states (thoughts, emotions, beliefs) are not separate from the brain. The self consists of brain activities and neural processes, not an immaterial or supernatural entity.
- **Thought Experiment (Altering the Brain):**
    - If future technology alters your brain, your fear disappears, memories change, and personality shifts—did they change your brain, or did they change *you*?
    - *Note:* According to Churchland, since they changed your brain and the brain *is* the self, **you are still the same entity**.

12. Maurice Merleau-Ponty

- **Phenomenology:** Focuses on how we experience the world through our bodies.
- **Perception:** The primary way we experience the self and the world.
- **An Embodied Being:** The self is embedded in the body. Bodily experiences shape our identity and how we understand the world around us.

- **The Body as an Active Agent:** An active part of how we perceive and interact with reality.
- **Self and the World:** Our sense of self is shaped by the world, but also shapes how we engage with it (a continuous feedback loop).

Thought Experiment (Different Body):

- *Scenario:* If you wake up tomorrow in a different body, your memories, personality, and thoughts are still yours. Would you still be the same person?
- *Note:* You will be a different person because you use the body as an **instrument to experience** the world.
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THE SELF, SOCIETY, AND CULTURE

1. Introduction: The Sociological Perspective

- **Core Question:** *Did society shape you, or did you shape yourself?* Before learning who we are independently, we must look at who we are as part of society.
- **Social Sciences Overview:** Systematic study of human behavior and society:
    - **Psychology:** Study of human behavior and mental processes (e.g., *What thoughts, emotions, and personality influence this student?*).
    - **Economics:** Study of production, distribution, and consumption (e.g., *How can financial circumstances influence them?*).
    - **Anthropology:** Study of culture and human origins (e.g., *How does culture affect beliefs and practices?*).
    - **Political Science:** Study of government and power (e.g., *How can the government/political environment affect their life?*).
    - **Sociology:** Study of human groups, institutions, and social structures (e.g., *How can their family and school shape who they are?*).

2. The Traditional View vs. Social Constructivist View

- **The Traditional/Independent View (Stevens, 1996):**
    - **Separate:** "Distinct from others" (*Ako, sila*, I have my own thoughts and identity, and others have theirs too).
    - **Self-Contained & Independent:** "In itself can exist"; everything important about me is inside me, like being contained in a box.
    - **Consistent & Unitary:** "Enduring, can persist"; the self is relatively stable with recurring personality traits.
    - **Private:** "Within"; if you want to know a person, you have to open the box and look inside.
- **Sociological Challenge to Independence:** Sociology challenges this picture by asking: *How independent are we really? How much do family, social media, and culture influence us?*
- **Social Constructivist View:**
    - The self is **malleable, dynamic, and continuously shaped through social interaction** in unceasing flux, through constant interaction with others and adaptation to social life.

3. Marcel Mauss: Two Faces of the Self

- We can adapt to different social contexts without completely losing our sense of who we are. There are **two dimensions**:
    1. **Moi (Personal Identity):** Who am I? Refers to a person's basic sense of identity, body, individuality, and biological "given-ness." It is what makes us experience ourselves as the same person across time.
    2. **Personne (Social Identity & Roles):** Who am I in society? Refers to social roles, family, religion, nationality, and institutions. It deals with social expectations, norms, and how we learn to behave in different contexts.
- **Cultural Expressions of Identity (e.g., Filipino Context):** Words like *"Opo"*, *"Po"*, *"Ate/Kuya"* signal age, status, closeness, respect, and roles—demonstrating how language, culture, and relationships shape the self.

4. Institutions That Shape the Self

- **Self and Family:**
    - Family is our **first social world**. Humans learn ways of living and their sense of self by being in a family.
    - What a family initiates a person to become serves as the basis for their progress.
    - **Family shapes:** Values, roles, expectations, behaviors, and sense of identity.
- **Gender and Self:**
    - Gender is a locus of the self subject to alteration, change, and development.
    - **Society forces a particular identity** upon us depending on our sex and/or gender.
    - *Important Note:* Learning an expectation does **not** mean we have to accept it.

5. Sociological Theories of Socialization and the Self

- **Gerry Lanuza (Modernity & the Self):**
    - Society shapes us, and **we shape our social world** (how our actions change the people and environment around us).
    - Filipino sociologist who wrote *The Constitution of the Self*.
    - In modern society, **identity is freely chosen** rather than dictated by tradition, allowing for greater freedom of self-cultivation and self-realization (though freedom can also lead to alienation and dehumanization).
- **George Herbert Mead (Development of the Social Self):**
    - The self develops entirely through social interaction across **three stages**:
        1. **Preparatory Stage (0–3 years old):** Imitation of behavior without understanding.
        2. **Play Stage (3–5 years old):** "I take the role of another" (role-taking).
        3. **Game Stage (Early school years, 8–9 years old):** "I understand multiple roles and expectations."
    - **Generalized Other:** The internalized understanding of the expectations of the wider social group or society.
- **Charles Horton Cooley (The Looking-Glass Self):**
    - Answers how other people become part of how we see ourselves through a **three-step process**:
        1. We imagine how others see us.
        2. We imagine how they judge us.
        3. We develop feelings about ourselves based on that imagined judgment.

6. Modern vs. Postmodern Societies and Consumption

- **Modern Society:**
  - Emphasizes **stability and structure**.
  - Developed around industrialization, institutions, science, progress, and order.
- **Postmodern Society:**
  - Emphasizes **flexibility, diversity, and constant change**.
  - Rejects the idea of one stable path, one truth, or one fixed identity.
- **Jean Baudrillard (The Consumer Self):**
  - French sociologist.
  - **"We don't consume only things. We consume meanings."**
  - People want a product → buy something new → feel good/status.
  - **Products become symbols of status and identity.**

ANTHROPOLOGICAL CONCEPTUALIZATION OF THE SELF

1. Self as Embedded in Culture

- **Learning Outcomes:**
  - Recognize what the field of anthropology can contribute to understanding the self.
  - Understand how culture and self are complementary concepts.
  - Discuss the cultural construction of the self and social identity.
  - Explain the concept of identity struggles.
  - Develop insights on how to achieve a sense of self, situated in multicultural and dynamic situations.
- **What is Anthropology?**
  - Study of humans, their cultures, and how they interact with their environment.
  - Focuses on how societies shape identity and self-perception.
  - Helps us understand that selfhood is culturally constructed and varies across societies.
- **Clifford Geertz (1973):**
  - Culture gives meaning to human experiences.
  - **Geertz's key ideas:**
    - Culture is not just behaviors or traditions, but a set of rules and instructions for life.
    - Humans rely on culture for guidance and survival.
  - Agreed with Max Weber: Humans create symbols and meanings to organize their world.
- **Humans as Cultural Animals (Robbins, 2012):**
  - Humans create meanings for: Objects, People, Behaviors, Emotions, Events.
  - These meanings shape how we act and interact with others.

2. Cultural Construction of the Self and Identity

- **Edward Tylor (1871):**
  - Defined culture as a complex whole including knowledge, beliefs, art, morals, laws, and customs.
  - Culture shapes individual identity and behavior.

- **Martin Sokefeld:**
  - Argued that the self is a cultural concept—what it means to be a "self" depends on societal beliefs.
  - Different cultures emphasize either individualism or collectivism.
- **Social Anthropology and Identity:**
  - Identity is shaped by social groups (family, ethnicity, religion, nationality).
  - **Ethnic identity:** A sense of belonging to a particular ethnic or cultural group.
- **Peacock (1986):**
  - *"Individuals are not mere robots nor self an entirely self-willed little god but a cultural individual—existing in freedom but also embodying that cultural mold in which he is cast in his particular society and historical epoch."*

3. Egocentric vs. Sociocentric Self

- **Egocentric Self (Western view):**
  - Self is independent, unique, and responsible for its actions.
  - Egocentric-self is capable of acting independently.
- **Sociocentric Self (Non-Western view):**
  - Self is defined by relationships and social roles.
  - Sociocentric self is context-dependent; no intrinsic self that can possess enduring qualities.
- **Examples of Sociocentric Self:**
  - **Christie Kiefer:** Japanese culture promotes a sociocentric self—identity depends on social harmony and group belonging. Emphasis on collectivism, duty, and interdependence.
  - **Francis Hsu:** Chinese self is also sociocentric, shaped by Confucian values. Importance of family, hierarchy, and social responsibility. Self is not isolated but exists within a web of relationships.

4. Identity Toolbox and Personal Naming

- **Identity Toolbox:**
  - Refers to the features of a person's identity that he or she chooses to emphasize in constructing a social self.
  - Includes gender, ethnicity, language, religion, and social roles.
  - Some aspects are chosen (career, beliefs), while others are assigned (race, family).
  - Other characteristics (personal appearance, socioeconomic status/SES) are not always used in every society.
- **Personal Naming:**
  - Naming is a powerful tool in shaping identity.
  - Establishes birthright, social identity, and belonging.
  - **Example (Aymara Indians):** Babies are not considered full members of society until they're formally named.

5. Rites of Passage and Identity Struggles

- **Three-Phased Rite of Passage (Arnold van Gennep):**
  - Changes in one's status and identity are marked by a three-phased rite of passage:
    1. **Separation:** Leaving familiar ground (e.g., moving to a new stage in life).
    2. **Liminality:** The in-between phase (e.g., adolescence training).
    3. **Incorporation:** Fully accepted into the new status (e.g., graduation, marriage).
- **Wallace and Fogelson (Identity Struggles):**

        - Identity is not fixed—people experience conflicts in self-perception.
        - Struggles occur when individuals feel torn between cultural expectations.
- **Katherine Ewing's Illusion of Wholeness:**
    - In multicultural societies, people adopt multiple self-identities.
    - Internal conflicts arise when different cultural models contradict each other.
    - To maintain a stable sense of self, individuals must integrate different cultural influences and suppress or modify certain identities when needed.
- **Golubovic (2011):**
    - To form a strong sense of self, people must:
        - Challenge traditions that limit personal growth.
        - Resist external labels imposed by society.
        - Develop self-awareness to navigate social expectations.

PSYCHOLOGICAL PERSPECTIVES OF THE SELF

1. Introduction to Psychology and the Self

- **Learning Objectives:**
    - Define and describe the different psychological concepts of the self.
    - Differentiate the various concepts of the self and identify their interrelationships.
    - Explain how the concepts of the self influence behavior.
    - Apply concepts of self in one's life to develop self-awareness and self-understanding.
- **What is Psychology?**
    - Studies behavior and mental processes to understand the self.
    - Explores how thoughts, emotions, and behaviors shape identity.
    - Different psychological theories provide perspective on how we develop and define the self.

2. William James - The "I" and the "Me"

- **I-self:**
    - Subjective self.
    - Thinking, perceiving, experiencing self.
    - Continuously aware and reflective.
- **Me-self:**
    - Objective self.
    - Self that is known and shaped by experiences.
    - **Composed of:**
        - **Material self:** physical body, possessions.
        - **Social self:** how others perceive us.
        - **Spiritual self:** inner identity, values, beliefs.

3. Carl Rogers - The Self Theory

- **Self-Concept:** The perception we have of ourselves.
- **Two Aspects of the Self:**
    - **Real Self:** Who we actually are.
    - **Ideal Self:** Who we aspire to be.
- **Congruence vs. Incongruence:**
    - **Congruence (Ideal Self = Real Self):** Normal/healthy self-esteem, well-being.

    - **Incongruence (Ideal Self ≠ Real Self):** Neurotic/anxiety, self-doubt.
- **Unconditional Positive Regard:** Refers to accepting and supporting someone without judgment or evaluation.

4. Donald Winnicott - Multiple vs. Unified Self, True vs. False Self

- **Multiple vs. Unified Self:**
    - We present different selves in different contexts.
    - A healthy self integrates these different aspects into a cohesive identity.
- **True vs. False Self:**
    - **True Self:** Authentic, spontaneous, driven by inner desires.
    - **False Self:** Created to conform to societal expectations.
- When the false self dominates, it can lead to feelings of inauthenticity and distress.

5. Albert Bandura - Self as Proactive and Agentic

- **Self as Proactive and Agentic:** Self is not passive—we actively shape our own experiences.
- **Self-efficacy:** Belief in one's ability to achieve goals.
- **Reciprocal determinism:** Interaction between behavior, environment, and personal factors.
- **Observational learning:** We learn by watching others (modeling).

6. Carl Jung - Self as Central Archetype

- **Self as Central Archetype:** The core of personality representing the unified whole of a person.
- **Individuation / Self-Realization:** The ultimate goal of development is self-realization (individuation)—the process of integrating all aspects of the psyche into a balanced self.
- **Key Archetypes That Shape the Self:**
    - **Persona:** Social mask we wear.
    - **Shadow:** Hidden, repressed aspects of the self.
    - **Anima/Animus:** Feminine and masculine aspects within us.

7. Sigmund Freud - Psychoanalytic Perspective

- **Three Parts of the Mind:**
    - **Id:** Instinctual drives (pleasure principle).
    - **Ego:** Rational self (reality principle).
    - **Superego:** Moral conscience (ideal self).
- **Personality Development:**
    - Shaped by early childhood experiences.
    - **Defense mechanisms** protect the self from anxiety (e.g., repression, denial, projection).
    - Freud's view: The self is a product of unconscious conflicts between desires, morality, and reality.

8. Erik Erikson - Psychosocial Stages

- **Lifespan Development:** The self evolves through 8 stages, each with a key challenge.
- **Stages of Psychosocial Development:**
    1. **Infancy:** Trust vs. Mistrust (Foundation of self-security)
    2. **Early Childhood:** Autonomy vs. Shame and Doubt
    3. **Preschool:** Initiative vs. Guilt

4. **School Age:** Industry vs. Inferiority
5. **Adolescence:** Identity vs. Role Confusion (Success: clear sense of identity; Failure: confusion about self and future roles)
6. **Young Adulthood:** Intimacy vs. Isolation (Self in relationships)
7. **Middle Adulthood:** Generativity vs. Stagnation (Self in terms of contribution to society)
8. **Maturity / Old Age:** Ego Integrity vs. Despair